

Project Title: Tinnitus Choir and Sound Installation Project

Participant information sheet: Please read and give consent via the first page of the questionnaire before proceeding to the questions.

1. Invitation to take part

You are being invited to participate in a research study. Before you decide whether to participate, it is important for you to understand why the research is being done and what it will involve. Please take time to read the following information carefully and feel free to ask us if you would like more information or if there is anything that you do not understand. Please also feel free to discuss this with your friends, relatives, and GP if you wish. We would like to stress that you do not have to accept this invitation and should only agree to take part if you want to.

2.What is the purpose of the study?

This creative research project aims to shift the stigma that exists around having tinnitus (the experience of hearing sounds in one or both ears), into a broader understanding of hearing difference. It seeks to move away from current feelings of needing to hide a change in one's hearing and instead contribute positive experiences of community making around tinnitus with the development of a new music project and sound installation. While tinnitus is experienced differently by each individual that it afflicts, it can be permanent and profoundly debilitating, and we know it is more common in musicians than the public at large. However, the impact of the stigma extends far beyond the realm of musicians and sound engineers as sparse discussions around hearing difference enter educational or public spaces.

3. Who can take part?

To answer the questionnaire, you must be over 18 years of age on or before the date you complete the form, self-identify or have been diagnosed as having tinnitus for at least one year, and reside in the UK.

The study will run online from March 2026 until January 2027

4. Do I have to take part?

Please note, you are a volunteer participant and will be able to leave the questionnaire at any time by closing the window without any of your information being submitted.

5. What will happen if I take part?

The online questionnaire has 18 multiple choice and descriptive question which invite you to write about your personal experience. Due to the nature of the questions it may take 10-20 minutes to answer the questionnaire.

The researcher, Lola de la Mata from the University of Liverpool is a third year PhD student in the Department of Music. She experiences chronic tinnitus. The study will gather information about participants' tinnitus, the loudness, texture and rhythmic quality. This will include information surrounding how often tinnitus is noticed and how it interacts with a participant's day to day.

Questions 9-11 may be answered optionally with a voice recording if preferred. If audio is uploaded, you will need to have indicated in the consent form whether this original audio (this is the audio you upload) may or may not be incorporated in the sound piece itself. This request is separate to consent for audio recordings being used for analysis purposes which can also be found on the Participant Consent Form.

6. Are there any risks in taking part?

There is the possibility for participants to experience a change in the perceived loudness of their tinnitus by taking part in the study while their attention is focused on their tinnitus.
Please do not take part if this causes you distress or concern.

7. Benefits to taking Part

A main benefit the study hopes to bring about, is for tinnitus to feel less isolating, less taboo for those who experience or perceive it as such.

Taking part in the study will offer participants who experience tinnitus (a sound or sounds invisible and inaudible to those outside of the person hearing them) the opportunity to have these hidden sounds form part of an externally tangible project. By shining a spotlight on an experience that is often overlooked, the sound art project aims to reach varied audiences as a means of raising awareness around this particular hearing difference, while bringing about a sense of community for those involved at different stages of the project, audience members who experience tinnitus, and those who don't.

8. How my data will be used

The University processes personal data as part of its research and teaching activities in accordance with the lawful basis of 'public task', and in accordance with the University's purpose of "advancing education, learning and research for the public benefit.

Under UK data protection legislation, the University acts as the Data Controller for personal data collected as part of the University's research. The Principal Investigator, Lola de la Mata, acts as the Data Processor for this study, and any queries relating to the handling of your personal data can be sent to L.De-La-Mata@liverpool.ac.uk

Further information on how your data will be used can be found in the table below:

How will my data be collected?	Through an online form
How will my data be stored?	All data including audio data will be stored on the researcher's m-drive storage system, kept strictly confidential and not disclosed in any public document.
How long will my data be stored for?	Data will be stored until the end of the project: September 2027.
What measures are in place to protect the security and confidentiality of my data?	Each answered questionnaire will be given a number. It will not require the entry of personal information (such as name or location/postcode). Entering an email will be optional and separated from the questionnaire answers before any analysis to ensure anonymity. Email use will be restricted to sharing updates on the status of the art project ex. performances, music releases with participants. All personal data such as email addresses will be stored on the researcher's m-drive

	storage system, kept strictly confidential and not disclosed in any public document.
Will my data be anonymised?	Yes
How will my data be used?	Some direct quote answers may be incorporated in the choral piece and sound installations. Other data will be analysed and utilised in the composition to decide on volume, pitch, repetition, looping etc. The choral work and sound installation will receive public performances in a minimum of 2 cities, with possible future public showcases. The choral piece will equally receive a digital release which will be made available for free to all participants who submit their email for this purpose. In addition to the music project, the quantitative and qualitative data collected will be analysed and published through academic papers, journal articles and conference presentations given by the principal investigator.
Who will have access to my data?	The data will only be accessed by the principal investigator Lola de la Mata. Anonymised and aggregated data will be shared with her supervisors, Dr. Jenn Kirby and Dr. Hannah Little. The same care and approach will be taken when including data in reports, artworks, journals and other forms of academic a public publishing formats to maintain full anonymity of participants. The information collected may be shared anonymously with other researchers at the discretion of the Principal Investigator Lola de la Mata to support other research in the future. The Principal Investigator will be the only person transcribing submitted audio files.
Will my data be archived for use in other research projects in the future?	Yes
How will my data be destroyed?	Data will only be destroyed in two instances: - A participant requests for their data to be removed from the study (prior to 1st March 2027) - When it is no longer required by academics for study.

9. Is there a fee involved in taking part in the study?

The study is voluntary, there is no fee offered for taking part in the online study. However, for those who would like to have copies of the final sound and music materials composed for the project, these will be made available for free to those who include an email address alongside their study. This will not cause conflicts in keeping your answers anonymous.

10. What will happen to the results of the study?

Participants who have entered an email address will receive updates about the study, information about performances and music releases developed with the data shared in the online questionnaire.

Email use will be restricted to sharing updates on the status of the art project ex. performances, music releases with participants.

Participants will not be identifiable from the results, and excerpts from the RAW audio uploaded by participants will not form part of any sonic work, unless they have consented to their voices being included.

All personal data such as email addresses, will be stored on the researcher's m-drive storage system, kept strictly confidential and not disclosed in any public document

11. What will happen if I want to stop taking part?

Participants can withdraw their participation in the study at any time and without reason given when filling out the questionnaire. Participants may simply close the window. To commit to taking part in the study select 'submit' at the end of the questionnaire.

Once answers have been submitted, as results are anonymised, each participant will be given a number in case they decide to withdraw prior to the analysis period which commences January 2027. All requests for withdrawal and data destruction must have been received prior to March 2027.

If you have any queries in this instance, please contact the Principal Investigator Lola de la Mata at L.De-La-Mata@liverpool.ac.uk.

12. What if I am unhappy or there is a problem?

If you are unhappy, or if there is a problem, please feel free to let us know by contacting the Principal Investigator Lola de la Mata at L.De-La-Mata@liverpool.ac.uk, and we will try to help. If you remain unhappy or have a complaint which you feel you cannot come to us with then you should contact the Research Ethics and Integrity Office at ethics@liv.ac.uk. When contacting the Research Ethics and Integrity Office, please provide details of the name or description of the study (so that it can be identified), the researcher(s) involved, and the details of the complaint you wish to make.

The University strives to maintain the highest standards of rigour in the processing of your data. However, if you have any concerns about the way in which the University processes your personal data, it is important that you are aware of your right to lodge a complaint with the Information Commissioner's Office by calling 0303 123 1113.

13. Who has reviewed this research?

The University of Liverpool
Central University Research Ethics Committees

14. Who can I contact if I have further questions?

Principal Investigator

Lola de la Mata L.De-La-Mata@liverpool.ac.uk

Support Organisations

If you have found any part of the experience of taking part to be distressing, please consider speaking with someone that you trust such as a family member or friend.

You may also consider speaking with one of the organisations below for additional support:

Tinnitus UK

<https://tinnitus.org.uk/>

The leading UK based Tinnitus charity.

They offer free support to anyone with tinnitus or caring for someone with tinnitus through online resources and a chat function.

Tinnitus Support Groups

<https://tinnitus.org.uk/support-for-you/service-finder/>

Samaritans UK

<https://www.samaritans.org/>

24 hour access, Suicide Prevention Charity.

Free to call 24hrs a day, 365 days a year: 116 123

They also have an online chat and email option jo@samaritans.org, please note it may take a number of days to receive a reply when emailing.

NHS UK

<https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/tinnitus/>

Guidance on tinnitus

NHS counselling

<https://www.nhs.uk/service-search/find-a-psychological-therapies-service/>